Portfolio review: Katie Aland

Reviewer: Ty Hatch, Weber State University, Web/UX Program
Date: April 3, 2026
Portfolio URL: https://creative-cat-3c53d8.netlify.app

⏱️ 55-second first impression

The site loads fast and identifies Katie clearly — name, focus area ("UX & Web Design Portfolio"), photo, and two featured projects are all visible quickly. The dark navy and maroon color scheme is consistent across every page, and a custom script logo in the nav shows intentional branding. Structurally, the foundation is solid.

But here's what a hiring manager would actually experience: the hero area is dominated by a stock photo of a phone that says nothing about Katie or her work. The two featured project cards both say "Created for Class Assignment" — that label is visible on the homepage before anyone clicks into the work. The "About & Contact" section takes up significant homepage space without adding value. In 55 seconds, a hiring manager sees: student, class work, and generic.

The deeper issue: nothing on the homepage creates intrigue. There's no hint of what problems Katie solved, what she cares about, or what makes her different. The violin-and-music angle — genuinely unusual and central to the Accelerando project — is completely invisible. So is the fact that she's redesigning a real business website for the golf course where she works. Both of those could be hooks. Neither is surfaced.

Gut reaction in one sentence: Competent structure, but nothing in the first 55 seconds gives a hiring manager a reason to click deeper.

Would a hiring manager click deeper? No. The homepage reads as a generic student portfolio. The most interesting material — the music-lessons platform, the real-client redesign, the personal connection between Katie's life and her design work — is hidden behind project pages that all look the same.

📊 Scores (1–3)

Problem clarity and intrigue: 1/3 (25%)

The Accelerando case study opens with a project overview paragraph describing what the platform does, not what problem it solves or why anyone should care. A problem statement exists — finding reputable music teachers is hard, bad teachers waste time and money — but it's buried below the overview and reads like a brief, not a hook. There is no "The assignment was X, but the real problem turned out to be Y."

Every other project page opens with some version of "I created this for a class assignment in [year]." CarDeal: "I created this webpage for a class assignment in 2026. For this assignment, I was given the contents of the webpage by my professor." Golf Course: "This project was created for a class assignment in 2025." This framing appears on 5 of 6 project pages.

The Accelerando project has real problem material buried in it — the insight that music students want structured lessons but also want control over what they play is genuinely interesting. But it's filed under "User Interviews," not surfaced as a narrative hook.

What would help: Rewrite the Accelerando opening to lead with the user insight: "Music students want structure *and* freedom — that tension shaped everything about this platform." For Lucky.golf, lead with: "I watch customers struggle with this website every shift. Here's what I'm doing about it."

Thinking, not process: 2/3 (25%)

This is the score with the most nuance, and the Accelerando case study earns it.

The usability testing section shows genuine design thinking. Katie identified a real interaction problem — the hover state persisted after clicking, confusing users — and fixed it. She discovered users weren't scrolling to see additional options on the lessons page and added auto-scroll behavior. These are specific, observation-driven design decisions.

The user interview section also shows reasoning: she learned her users wanted structure with customization, which led to three lesson package tiers (Casual, Focused, Professional). The connection between research finding and design decision is visible.

But outside the Accelerando project, there's no thinking visible anywhere. Every other project uses the identical Overview/Process/Takeaways three-column format. The content is process description: "I used HTML, SASS, and Bootstrap." "I used HTML, CSS, Bootstrap, and Figma." No reasoning about design choices, no alternatives considered, no trade-offs discussed.

What would help: For the Lucky.golf redesign especially, add at least one decision point: "The original site had [X] navigation items. I tested [two approaches] and chose [Y] because [Z]." One "why" does more than listing every technology used.

Show the work: 1/3 (20%)

This is the biggest gap. Katie has built coded, functional websites — Golf Course, CarDeal, Handicap Calculator, Lucky.golf — but none are linked as live, explorable work. A hiring manager can only look at a single static screenshot of each.

The Accelerando Figma prototype has no Figma link. The entire interactive experience — the thing that makes it a design project — is invisible. The persona image is too small to read. The user flow diagrams are similarly compressed.

There are no video walkthroughs, no embedded prototypes, no micro-interactions, no before/after comparisons. Every project is a static hero image + text summary. On the signal strength spectrum (live link → prototype → video → annotated screens → static screenshots), this portfolio sits at the bottom.

This matters especially because Katie can code. The framework's strongest 2026 differentiator — shipped, working artifacts — is available to her and she's not using it.

What would help: Add live links to every coded project. Add the Figma prototype link to Accelerando. These are the quickest wins in the entire review — the work exists, it just isn't accessible.

Impact and outcomes: 1/3 (15%)

The usability testing data table in the Accelerando case study is the only quantitative data in the portfolio. It shows task completion times and first clicks for 4 users across 3 tasks — real data. But it's presented raw, without analysis. There's no "User 1 took 1:22 on mobile because they started from the homepage card instead of the nav — this told us the homepage needed a clearer path."

No other project has outcomes at all. The Takeaways columns describe what Katie learned about coding ("I learned how to build a pagination," "I learned how to make responsive forms"), not what changed for users. No project completes: "Because of this decision, [X] changed for [Y]."

The Lucky.golf redesign mentions a goal — "make the website have less information overload and be simpler to navigate" — but there's no evidence of whether the redesign achieved it. No before/after, no user feedback, no metrics.

What would help: For Accelerando, add 2–3 sentences interpreting the usability data: what patterns emerged, what changed as a result. For Lucky.golf, add a before/after comparison showing the navigation simplification with specific numbers (pages reduced, clicks reduced, etc.).

Growth signal and AI fluency: 1/3 (15%)

The About page reveals a genuine person with a real story — violin background, the path from Google Slideshows to CS to UX, tutoring and mentoring experience. That's good personal context. But there's no signal of growth *as a designer*.

Every project is presented as a clean success. The Takeaways sections describe skills learned ("I learned how to make responsive forms") but not design evolution. There's no progression between projects, no "here's what I'd do differently," no evidence that later work applied lessons from earlier projects.

Zero mention of AI tools, AI workflow, or AI awareness anywhere. No mention of industry trends, emerging tools, or design community engagement. The Skills section lists foundational tools (HTML, CSS, SCSS, Bootstrap, JavaScript, Figma, Photoshop) — none suggesting awareness of where the field is heading.

What would help: Add a brief "What I'd do differently" to each project. Mention AI tools in the workflow, even experimentally. One sentence about using Claude or Figma AI for ideation would signal awareness. The bar isn't expertise — it's curiosity.

Total: 6/15

This score reflects the portfolio's communication, not Katie's ability. She has real usability testing experience, coded and deployed projects, a genuine client relationship (Lucky.golf), and personal domain knowledge that connects her projects to real communities. The gap is almost entirely presentation — the strongest material is buried, the weakest material is prominent, and the identical template format flattens everything.

🏗️ Case study structure assessment

Quantity

1 case study (Accelerando) and 5 additional project pages. The framework recommends 1 deep case study + 1 additional project + evidence of growth. The ratio is inverted: too many shallow pages, not enough depth where it matters.

The Photoshop image (Doorway to Fantasy) and CarDeal page don't demonstrate UX thinking and dilute the portfolio. The strongest candidate for a second deep case study — Lucky.golf, a real business with real users — is stuck in the same 3-box template as everything else.

Aland Accelerando: 7-section check

Section	Present?	Notes
1. Hero (hook + preview + result)	Partial	Screenshot + title, but no hook, no headline result. Title is a label ("Aland Accelerando Figma Prototype"), not a story.

Section	Present?	Notes
2. Overview (role, tools, problem)	Partial	Description and problem statement exist, but the role, tools, and timeline aren't stated. The problem reads as a brief.
3. Discovery (research + reasoning)	Yes	User interviews conducted, persona created, findings led to lesson package structure. Reasoning present.
4. Design process (iterations + decisions)	Weak	Color palette, typography, and component specs shown, but no iteration visible. No decision points with alternatives.
5. Final design (experienceable)	No	No Figma link, no prototype embed, no video. Design is not experienceable.
6. Impact (specific outcomes)	Partial	Usability testing data exists with real numbers, but no analysis or interpretation.
7. Reflection (specific learnings)	Partial	The usability section describes what was learned and changed, but isn't framed as a reflection. No "what I'd do differently."

Lucky.golf: 7-section check

Section	Present?	Notes
1. Hero (hook + preview + result)	Partial	Screenshot of the site, but no hook. Just "Lucky.golf Website / Website Redesign."

Section	Present?	Notes
2. Overview (role, tools, problem)	Partial	Mentions it's a real business and the redesign goal. No role or timeline stated.
3. Discovery (research + reasoning)	No	No user research mentioned despite Katie having direct access to customers.
4. Design process (iterations + decisions)	No	Process section lists technologies only.
5. Final design (experienceable)	No	Static screenshot only. No live link.
6. Impact (specific outcomes)	No	Goals stated but no outcomes measured.
7. Reflection (specific learnings)	Partial	Takeaways describe goals, not learnings from the process.

Quality notes: Accelerando is approximately 500 words (slightly under the 600–1,500 target). Visual ratio is reasonable but several images are too small to read. Breadcrumb navigation bug: reads "Home / Projects / Golf Handicap Calculator" instead of the case study name. All five non-case-study pages use the identical three-column layout (Overview/Process/Takeaways) — the repetition signals template compliance, not individual thinking.

🚩 Red flags

- ❌ Generic positioning — "UX & Web Design Portfolio" with no specialization or differentiator
- ❌ "Class assignment" framing on 5 of 6 projects — stated prominently before work is shown
- ❌ Identical structure on all non-case-study pages — same 3-box layout signals template, not thinking

- ❌ Broken resume download links — both "Download my Resume" buttons on the About page point to "#."
- ❌ Breadcrumb bug on case study page — reads "Golf Handicap Calculator" instead of "Aland Accelerando."
- ❌ No live project links — coded, deployed projects exist but aren't linked
- ❌ No Figma prototype link — the primary case study artifact is invisible
- ❌ About page is excessively long — 1,000+ words of personal essays that don't serve a hiring manager
- ❌ Persona and user flow images are too small to read
- ❌ Zero mention of AI tools or industry awareness
- ❌ Homepage hero is a stock photo that communicates nothing about Katie's work
- ✅ Contact info present — form + LinkedIn in footer
- ✅ Fast loading
- ✅ No typos observed in prominent positions
- ✅ Appears responsive

🎯 Highest-leverage change

What if the Lucky.golf redesign became a real case study instead of a 3-box summary?

Katie's most compelling project is buried in the same shallow template as a Photoshop exercise. Lucky.golf is work for an actual business (Crane Field and Remuda golf courses) with real users, real constraints, and a stated goal (reduce information overload, simplify navigation). Katie works at Crane Field — she has direct user access and domain knowledge that most students don't have.

If this became a full case study with the depth of the Accelerando project — user research with actual golf course customers, before/after navigation analysis, specific design decisions with reasoning, measurable outcomes — Katie would have two case studies: one showing UX process (Accelerando) and one showing shipped impact for a real client (Lucky.golf). That combination is significantly stronger than one case study and five shallow project summaries.

✨ The potential signal

Katie's strongest signal is the intersection of personal domain knowledge and design work — and it's almost completely hidden.

She works at Crane Field Golf Course and is redesigning their actual website. She's been a violinist for over a decade and built a music lessons platform. These aren't random class projects — they connect to real communities she belongs to. A hiring manager who sees "I redesigned the website for the golf course where I work, because I watched customers struggle with it every day" is going to lean in. That's what Joanna Bloor calls the Potential Gap: people say yes to a future they want to build with someone. It signals a person who sees problems in the world around them and acts on them.

Right now, none of that connective tissue is visible. The homepage doesn't mention it. The project pages don't frame it. The About page buries it in a wall of personal essay. If Katie surfaced the pattern — "I design for communities I'm part of" — it would be a genuine differentiator most student portfolios can't claim.

📄 ATS check

Resume present? Broken link — both "Download my Resume" buttons on the About page link to "#".

ATS-optimized? Unknown: no resume accessible.

97% of tech companies use ATS. The portfolio convinces humans; the resume survives machines. Katie needs both. A single-column, standard-header, keyword-optimized resume needs to be uploaded and linked as a priority.

🧭 Recommended path

Path 3: Software as a gift — ship something real for a real person.

Katie is already doing this with Lucky.golf — she's just not presenting it that way. She has domain knowledge (works at the golf course), user access (interacts with customers daily), and technical skills to build and ship. The Golf Handicap Calculator is another version of this: a functional tool for a real use case.

The path forward is to lean into what she's already doing. Give the Lucky.golf redesign the case study depth it deserves, ship it, and frame it as: "I built this for the business where I work because I saw a real problem." Then do it again for the music community, the violin community, the tutoring community. Each project becomes proof that Katie identifies problems and ships solutions, not just completes assignments.

📍 Where to start (priority order)

1. **Fix the broken resume links**: Both buttons point to "#". Quick fix, high credibility impact.
2. **Fix the breadcrumb bug on the case study page**: Currently reads "Golf Handicap Calculator." Small but visible.
3. **Add live links to coded projects**: Golf Course, CarDeal, Handicap Calculator, and Lucky.golf are deployed somewhere — link to them. Instantly moves "Show the Work" from static screenshots to explorable artifacts.
4. **Add the Figma prototype link to Accelerando**: Let hiring managers experience the design, not just read about it.
5. **Elevate Lucky.golf to a full case study**: Use the 7-section structure. Research real users (she has access). Frame the real problem. Show before/after. Measure impact.
6. **Rewrite the Accelerando opening**: Lead with the user insight ("Music students want structure *and* freedom — that tension shaped everything"), not the project description.
7. **Cut the About page by 60%**: Remove the personal essays (My Story, Why UX?, Design Style). Keep: 2-sentence intro, employment, skills, working resume download. A hiring manager needs positioning, not autobiography.
8. **Remove or consolidate weaker projects**: The Photoshop image and CarDeal page don't demonstrate UX thinking. Remove them or move to a "More Work" section that doesn't compete with case studies.

9. **Replace the homepage hero**: The stock phone image adds nothing. Show a preview of actual work — an Accelerando screenshot, a before/after of Lucky.golf, anything that demonstrates what Katie does.

📝 Summary

Katie has real assets most student portfolios lack: technical coding skills, domain expertise in communities she belongs to, actual usability testing experience, and a real-client redesign project in progress. The portfolio's problem isn't substance — it's presentation. The strongest material is buried, the weakest material is prominent, and the identical template format flattens everything into "class assignments."

The core reframe: Katie isn't a student who completed assignments. She's a designer who builds things for communities she's part of. The portfolio needs to tell that story.

Review conducted by Web/UX Portfolio Review Framework v1.2 on 3 Apr 2026 | Framework created by Ty Hatch